by the turn of events and trusting in their commanding officers can hardly be faulted. Yet it was they who had to collectively pay the price.

Meanwhile, the 4 Rajput Battalion HQ was situated at Sapper Camp, in the vicinity of Bridge 1 while all its sub-units were widely dispersed. Lieutenant Colonel Brahmanand Avasthy had received a series of confusing orders on the night of 17-18 November from GOC 4 Division through 65 Brigade HQ which henceforth placed him under the command of 62 Brigade. At around 8 a.m. on 18 November, just before going off air, 65 Brigade HQ sent a brief signal to 4 Rajput asking them to withdraw to Dirang Dzong. After that, there was total silence from Cheema's HQ. Simultaneously, HQ 62 Brigade had gone eerily silent by then and there were reports coming in from the dispersed Rajput companies that the Chinese were infiltrating into their immediate areas.

Unaware of 62 Brigade's hurried exodus from Se-la, concerned mainly by the wide dispersal of his troops (at dawn, Charlie Company near Labrang had been attacked by the Chinese but it had held firm), Avasthy radioed Major Kukrety, the Delta Company commander, at 8 a.m. on the Bhutan border to rejoin the Battalion HQ at Sapper Camp. However, it soon became obvious that the Chinese were present in reasonable numbers between the Delta Company location and Sapper Camp, so an hour later, the order was modified and Delta Company was told to withdraw to the foothills independently. As per his understanding of the situation, once the Chinese had begun their offensive, 62 Brigade was expected to hold Se-la while 4 Rajput along with 19 MLI were to form the bulwark of Dirang Dzong's defences. It seemed pointless to ask Delta Company to try and fight through to Battalion HQ.

Avasthy had also spoken to Major K. P. P. Nair asking him to hold fast and assume command of all troops to the north of the road and link up with Battalion HQ which would try and get to Dirang Dzong via the northern ridge. According to Nair, he too received a second message from Battalion HQ telling him they were withdrawing shortly thereafter, and that he too should proceed independently to the foothills. After this last communication, wireless contact with Battalion HQ was broken.

Whatever the reality, the bottom line was that by the time the 62 Brigade vehicle convoy reached Bridge 2 and were ambushed, there were no covering troops from 4 Rajput in the immediate vicinity. This allowed